



The Mughal Empire



JOHN F. RICHARDS



The Mughal empire was one of the largest centralized states known in pre-modern world history. It was founded in the early 1500s and by the end of the following century the Mughal emperor ruled almost the entire Indian subcontinent with a population of between 100 and 150 millions. As well as military success, the Mughal emperors displayed immense wealth and the ceremonies, etiquette, music, poetry, and exquisitely executed paintings and objects of the imperial court fused together to create a distinctive aristocratic high culture.

In this volume, Professor John Richards traces the history of this magnificent empire from its creation in 1526 to its breakup in 1720. He stresses the dynamic quality of Mughal territorial expansion, their institutional innovation in land revenue, coinage and military organization, ideological change, and the relationship between the emperors and Islam. Professor Richards also analyzes institutions particular to the Mughal empire, such as the *jagir* system, and explores Mughal India's links with the early modern world.

The Mughal Empire offers a concise and up-to-date synthesis of this spectacular period in the history of India, Pakistan and Bangladesh. It will be widely read by students and specialists of South Asian history and civilization and will be of interest to travellers wishing to know more about the background to the great Mughal monuments.

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THE NEW CAMBRIDGE HISTORY
OF INDIA

The Mughal Empire

THE NEW CAMBRIDGE HISTORY OF INDIA

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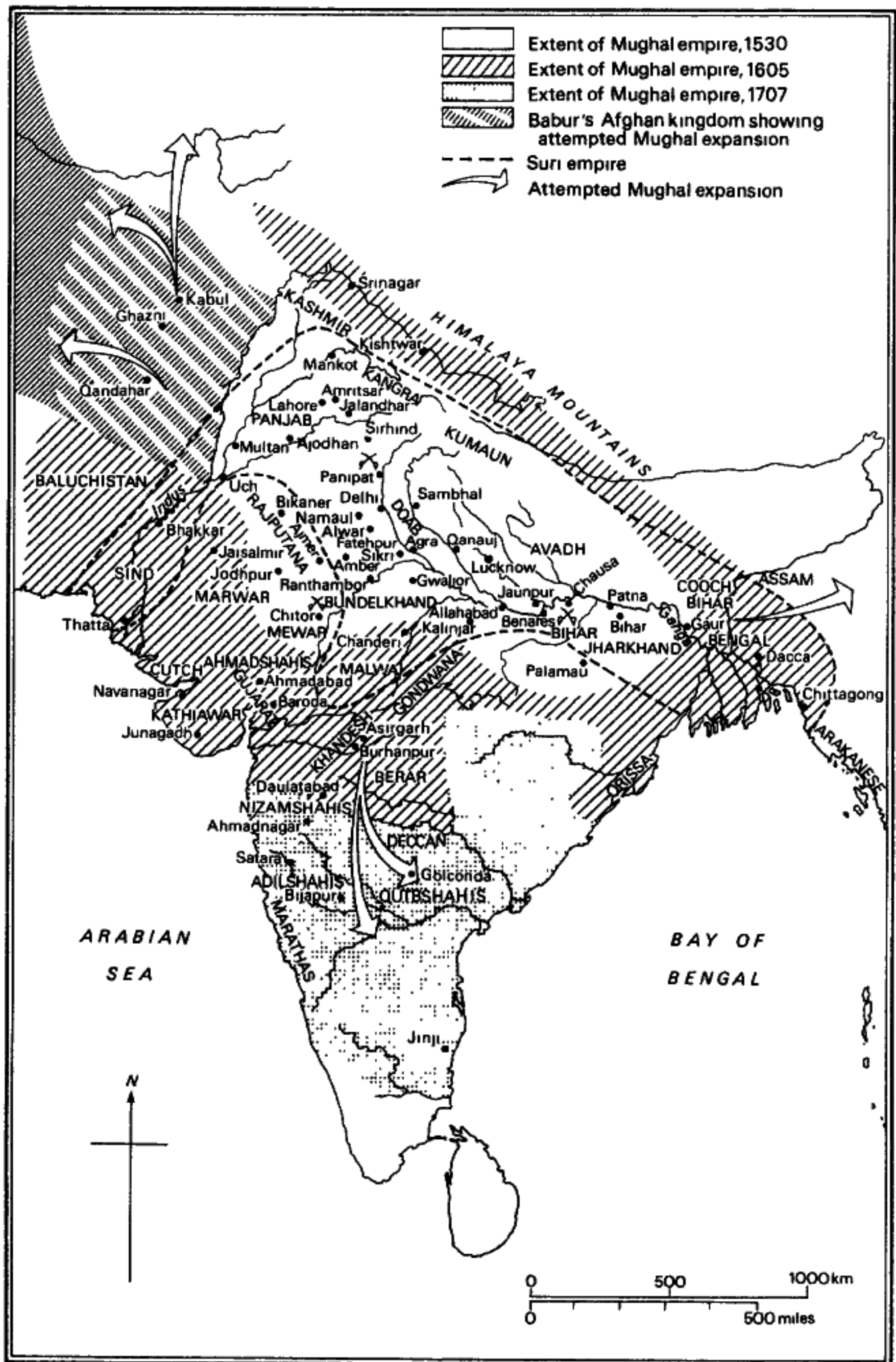
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Frontispiece The Mughal empire, 1526 to 1707
 Source: F. Robinson, *Atlas of the Islamic World since 1500*
 (Oxford, 1982), p. 59.

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Dedicated to the memory of my mother

ELLA HIGGINS RICHARDS

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death in 1553 the Sur domains were divided by treaty into the Punjab; Agra and Delhi; Bihar and the eastern region; and Bengal. Each was ruled by a son or relative of Sher Shah Sur. Everywhere the Sur administrative system was breaking up. Drought in preceding years brought famine conditions by early 1555. Popular distress contributed to Afghan demoralization as mortality from starvation and disease shot up.

Humayun, now fully energized, led his army from Kabul back to the northern Indian plain in late 1554. The Mughals met little resistance until Sikandar Shah Sur, the ruler of the Punjab, assembled a large Afghan army at the town of Sirhind. A hard-fought battle ended with Mughal victory. Sikandar Shah Sur fled the battlefield and with him went any hope of further Afghan resistance. Humayun entered Delhi and restored Babur's monarchy by mid-1555.

The Mughal restoration was complete. But Humayun had little time left. Within seven months, in January, 1556, he met a fatal accident on the steps of his library in the fortress at Delhi. Humayun's nobles concealed the fact of his death for seventeen days until they could secure a stable arrangement for the succession. The agreement arrived at permitted Humayun's young son Akbar, then twelve years of age, to be crowned under the title Jalal-ud-din Muhammad Akbar.

AKBAR 1556-1605

During his long reign Akbar made no emotional or political commitment to a permanent capital. His court, household, chancery, treasury, stables, and armories moved from one urban setting to another to suit changing circumstances. When desired, the Timurid ruler became readily mobile. The massive tents of the imperial encampment, emplaced after the day's march, retained the grandeur and fixed spatial arrangements of a permanent city built of stone. The emperor himself, rather than a physical site, was the capital of the empire.

Akbar's changing strategic foci are reflected in the four successive sites – Agra, Fatehpur Sikri, Lahore, and Agra – adopted as royal capitals. Each phase in his grand strategy is defined by increased Mughal power, resources and territory as the precarious regime inherited by the young Timurid prince grew into a multi-regional empire.

CONQUEST AND STABILITY

BAIRAM KHAN AS REGENT

Bairam Khan, a dominant member of Humayun's nobility, assumed the role of protector or regent for the young Akbar. Several months after Akbar's enthronement, Hemu, a minister and general of one of the presumptive heirs of Islam Shah Sur, marched with a huge army to attack Delhi. Hemu, a Hindu Vaisya or member of a literate, mercantile caste, who had risen from humble circumstances to be a general for the Sur regime, claimed royal status by employing the ancient Sanskrit title of Raja Vikramaditya. Had he succeeded this would have been a remarkable reassertion of the Sanskritic/Brahminical monarchical tradition in North India – long subservient to Muslim rulers. A much smaller Mughal army assembled by Bairam Khan with Akbar at his side met Hemu's forces at Panipat, the site of the climactic Lodi-Timurid battle three decades earlier. The Sur forces nearly overwhelmed the Mughals but for a stray arrow that wounded Hemu and brought him as a prisoner to the Mughal commanders. Together Bairam Khan and his young protégé slew the helpless Sur general. The dead commander's troops, thoroughly demoralized, rapidly deserted the battlefield to give the victory to the Mughals.

In the next six months the Mughals won another major battle against Sikandar, one of the Sur princes, who then fled east to Bengal. Under Bairam Khan's direction Mughal armies occupied Lahore and seized Multan in the Punjab. In 1558 they took possession of Ajmer, the aperture to Rajasthan, after the flight of its Muslim ruler. Late in the same year a Timurid commander defeated Ibrahim, the remaining Sur prince, and annexed Jaunpur, capital of the former Sultanate of Jaunpur in the eastern Gangetic valley. By early 1557 a Mughal force besieged a Sur commander in control of Gwalior fort, the greatest stronghold north of the Narmada river. After nearly two years the beleaguered Afghan garrison surrendered in January, 1558.

This aggressive flurry of activity put the vital cities and strongholds of a compact region between Lahore, Delhi, Agra, and Jaunpur under Mughal control. This was Hindustan, the old heartland of Muslim political and military power in North India. The Mughals, like their predecessors, now tapped the immense agricultural productivity and busy trade of the epicenter of the Indo-Gangetic plain. Lahore and Delhi stood together as western and eastern redoubts – symbols of Muslim victory and domination in Hindu north India.

By the fourth regnal year Bairam Khan had launched a drive to the south into Rajasthan and Malwa. At this juncture a new political struggle put a temporary halt to expansion. Akbar, then turned seventeen, chafed in adolescent rebellion against Bairam Khan's stern authority. Several clashes with the regent brought the young king to an alliance with a dissident faction of the nobility. This clique consisted of Adham Khan, Akbar's Turani foster brother, the son of his wet-nurse, and a group of his relatives. Hamida Begam, Akbar's mother, actively encouraged the planned coup. Ethnic and religious friction underlay dissatisfaction with the all-powerful minister. The orthodox Sunni Muslim Central Asian (Turani) nobles disliked deferring to a Persian Shia like Bairam Khan. Their dislike intensified when Bairam Khan appointed a fellow Shia theologian as religious minister (*sadr*) who controlled state patronage in the form of gifts, grants and jobs.

In March, 1560, Akbar, who was at Delhi, demanded Bairam Khan's resignation as chief minister. Feeling the erosion of his position, Bairam Khan complied. The disgraced minister could choose between continued personal service at court (but not as regent), or temporary exile in a pilgrimage to Mecca. Choosing the pilgrimage, the unfortunate minister was assassinated on his journey by an Afghan with a long-standing personal grievance, before he embarked for the sea passage.

TOWARD AUTONOMOUS RULE

Between 1560 and 1571, the first period of his mature rule, Akbar remained at Agra. For two years Maham Anaga, Akbar's foster mother, Adham Khan, and Shihab-ud-din, a cousin who served as governor of Delhi, exercised nearly complete political and fiscal powers.

The troika wasted little time in resuming military activity. A Mughal field army under the command of Adham Khan and Pir Muhammad Khan invaded the kingdom of Malwa. The Mughal army defeated Baz Bahadur, the Sultan of Malwa, at the town of Sarangpur. The defeated ruler fled to the Sultanate of Khandesh for refuge leaving his harem, treasure, and war elephants. His principal queen, Rupamati, famed for her beauty, took poison rather than lose her honor in captivity. This tragic theme has inspired many poetic compositions since that date.

Despite its initial success the campaign proved a disaster from

Akbar's point of view. Adham Khan retained virtually all the spoils. The victorious commander then followed Central Asian practice by wholesale slaughter of the surrendered garrison, their wives and children, and many Muslim theologians and Sayyids (descendants of the Prophet). The opprobrium this generated greatly upset Akbar. The emperor rode in person to the army's headquarters to confront Adham Khan and relieve him of command. Akbar sent his other leading general, Pir Muhammad Khan, in pursuit of Baz Bahadur deep into the territory of the Deccan Muslim Sultanate of Khandesh. But the rulers of Khandesh and Berar and the royal fugitive Baz Bahadur allied to beat back the Mughal army.

Baz Bahadur temporarily regained control of Malwa until, in the next year, another Mughal army invaded and firmly annexed the kingdom. Malwa became a province embedded within the nascent imperial administration of the Timurid regime. Baz Bahadur survived as a refugee at various courts until, eight years later, in 1570, he took service with his conqueror as a Mughal noble (*amir*).

Shortly after the return of the Mughal armies, in late 1561, Akbar's conflict with Adham Khan flared up again. Feeling slighted by the appointment of another noble as chief minister (*vakil*), Adham Khan attacked and killed the new minister in his own audience hall in the palace. When the still armed Adham Khan confronted Akbar in the harem, he was struck down by the outraged young emperor and thrown from a terrace into the palace courtyard. Still alive, Adham Khan was dragged up and thrown to the courtyard once again by Akbar to ensure his death. This dramatic event is described in full detail in the histories of the reign and graphically portrayed in miniature paintings. The fate of Adham Khan became part of a growing corpus of stories that together formed the legendary Akbar.

Akbar immediately assumed full executive powers as ruler. In place of the office of chief minister he created four specialized ministerial posts for financial, military, household, and religious affairs. In so doing, he removed one focal point for noble rebellion and discontent. No single member of the Mughal nobility would have unquestioned preeminence and thereby attract dissident adherents. The threat of an over-mighty chief minister had been diverted – at least until the waning days of the dynasty.

Beyond these measures the young ruler faced the problem of political organization. Military victories were not enough; the new

regime required a coherent political statement. Somehow Akbar had to interweave the strands of his inherited Timurid charisma and authority, of centralized authority inherited from the Surs and the Sultans of Delhi, and the notion of Islamic legitimacy. If he failed to do so, North India would undergo once again war between Mughals, Afghans, Rajputs, and regional Muslim rulers which had disfigured the previous three decades. Merely to survive as a ruler, he must win over or break the power of two groups: the Muslim nobility with its armed power and wealth, and the religious elites of Islam, the *ulema* and Sufi shaikhs, with their influence over the Muslim community in India.

NEW CONQUESTS

In 1561 Sher Khan Sur, son of Adil Shah Sur, still unsubdued, marched from the great Afghan bastion at Chunar toward Jaunpur with a large army. Two Mughal commanders, Zaman Khan and Bahadur Khan, Central Asian Uzbek nobles, dealt a sharp defeat to the Afghans and seized arms, treasure and war elephants. Zaman Khan duly reported the victory to the emperor, but retained the battle plunder without permission. Akbar was incensed at the violation of royal prerogatives – especially in the case of the war elephants whose use was a royal symbol in India. He marched in person to Kara and confronted the two generals in person. They paid formal homage to him and dutifully handed over the spoils of battle. The seizure of Chunar rounded out the first phase of Mughal expansion in the east.

In the two years after the departure of Bairam Khan, the Mughal ruler, still not past his twentieth birthday, displayed his true political and organizational capabilities. He asserted his position as an absolutist ruler demanding deference from all. Even victorious generals could be brought to submission if prompt vigorous action were taken by the emperor. Akbar became his own commander-in-chief and most capable strategist and field commander.

As a symbol of his new-found autonomy and military prowess, Akbar sent a mission to the Baghela Rajput ruler Ram Chand at Kalinjar, his capital, to induce the famed singer-musician Tansen to come to the Mughal court at Agra. Ram Chand, who had rejected earlier overtures from the Surs, dared not refuse and sent Tansen with his instruments and lavish presents to Akbar's court. Akbar is said to have given Tansen two hundred thousand rupees as a gift on the

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occasion of his first performance at court. Acquisition of Tansen's services stimulated Akbar's active patronage of music. Tansen, and after him, his sons and other pupils actively cultivated what was to become known as North Indian or Hindustani music.

After Malwa the first major target was the hilly, thinly populated kingdom of Garha-Katanga, or Gondwana, famed for its herds of wild elephants. A Mughal army under Asaf Khan, an Uzbek noble, invaded the kingdom in 1564. The Rajput queen, Rani Durgavati of the Candela lineage, died commanding her armies in a futile defense. The Mughals swept aside the remaining Rajput defenders and marched on the capital at Chauragarh. The young Candela prince Bir Narayan died in battle. Most of his female relatives perished in the bloody rite of suicide and immolation in flames reserved for noble Rajput women and their attendants (*jauhar*). Garha-Katanga became a huge district (*sarkar*) incorporated within the just acquired province of Malwa. As was the case with all such imperial annexations the boundaries and internal divisions of the kingdom remained unaltered.

THE UZBEK REVOLT

In 1564, trouble flared up with the Uzbek nobles, Khan Zaman and his brother Bahadur Khan, who had defeated the Afghans at Chunar. Although most of these nobles had returned with Humayun to India, Uzbek allegiance to the Timurids was not as firm as it might have been. The Uzbek nobles traced their lineage back to Shaiban, the Uzbek ruler, who had been Babur's nemesis a half century earlier and whose descendants continued to rule in Central Asia. Accustomed to a more egalitarian political tradition, these grandees resented Akbar's imperious ruling style. Considerable friction existed also between the staunch Sunni Muslim Uzbeks and the Shia Persian nobles employed in Mughal service. Not surprisingly, the Uzbek dissidents determined to test Akbar early while the young ruler was still solidifying his position.

In 1564 Abdullah Khan, governor of Malwa, went into open revolt. Akbar marched with an army to Mandu and drove the rebel with his followers to seek refuge in the still-independent Sultanate of Gujarat. Early in 1565 Akbar's attempt to recall the senior Uzbek officer in Awadh, touched off a unified Uzbek rebellion. A confused series of battles and negotiations ended in early 1566 with Akbar's withdrawal to Agra and the rebels still holding the eastern provinces.

Akbar also faced a potential challenge from his half-brother, Mirza Muhammad Hakim, who governed Kabul and its surrounding districts. Mirza Muhammad Hakim's hold on Kabul was threatened by the Timurid ruler of Badakhshan (whose kingdom had been restored to him in 1530 by Babur). Despite Akbar's assistance, the Badakhshani armies were besieging Kabul in 1566. Muhammad Hakim left a garrison in place and retreated with his army towards the Indus river in the Punjab plain.

The still unreconciled Uzbek nobles, learning of these events, invited Muhammad Hakim to invade India. They, in turn, proclaimed him the legitimate Mughal ruler by having Muhammad Hakim's name read in the Friday prayers (the *khutba*) in the great mosque at Jaunpur. Encouraged by this, Muhammad Hakim marched through the Punjab and besieged Lahore. At this critical point, a group of Timurid nobles bearing the title Mirza or prince also rebelled and tried to seize Delhi. The elderly leader, Muhammad Sultan Mirza, was descended from Timur's second son (instead of Akbar's descent from the third son). In theory, at least, Muhammad Sultan, or his numerous sons and grandsons, could claim Akbar's throne. This claim was strengthened by intermarriage with Timurid princesses from Akbar's line. Loyalist commanders drove off the rebels and captured Muhammad Sultan Mirza. The remaining Mirzas sought refuge and support from the Rana of Mewar and other Rajput rulers in Rajasthan.

Akbar responded to this crisis by ignoring the Mirzas and marching to confront his half-brother at Lahore. Mirza Muhammad Hakim retreated to Kabul, now cleared of the Badakhshan army. Akbar chose not to pursue him. For the next decade, Mirza Muhammad Hakim acted as a sovereign ruler at Kabul and posed a continuing danger to Akbar's regime in India.

The emperor wheeled his army round and marched east to dislodge the Uzbeks from the cities and fortresses they had seized. In June, in the midst of the monsoon, the emperor reached Manikpur on the bank of the rain-swollen Ganges. The Uzbeks were encamped across the river and unaware that the royal army had arrived so quickly. Akbar led a surprise night river crossing and attacked the rebels at dawn. In the ensuing fracas Akbar's troops killed or captured for execution the Uzbek nobles who had opposed him. In the closing phase of the revolt, the emperor drove the dispirited Mirzas and their followers south to take refuge with the Sultan of Gujarat.

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Somehow the young emperor survived one of the most dangerous episodes in his career. Throughout this three-year period he relied as much on negotiation and diplomacy as on force to deter the rebels. His Timurid ancestry was an asset, but it alone could not ensure fidelity from all his nobles. In the end, battle decided the issue.

THE NEW NOBILITY

The Uzbek revolt underscored Akbar's vulnerability vis-a-vis his nobles. These warrior-grandeers drew upon inherited positions of power, authority, and influence with their kinsmen. The amirs were heirs to bellicose martial traditions that emphasized personal honor, dignity, and bravery on the field of battle. Always armed themselves, they commanded varying numbers of personal slaves, dependent kinsmen, and paid retainers.

The small cadre of fifty-one nobles who returned to India with Humayun in 1555 were nearly all foreign-born Muslims.⁴ Twenty-seven, or over half, were from Central Asia. These were high-status chiefs from Chaghatai Turkish or Uzbek Central Asian lineages. By this time members of both lineages could claim varying degrees of blood relationship with Humayun. All were imbued with the egalitarian and divisive attitudes of the Central Asian Turkish tribes. And they were well aware that Mirza Muhammad Hakim offered a legitimate alternative to Akbar's rule. A second group consisted of sixteen Persian Shi'ite nobles, including Bairam Khan, who formed the primary counterweight to the Turanis or Central Asian *beks*. The Iranis were more willing to accede to the notion of an unchallenged *pad shah* or emperor in the Persian imperial tradition.

Akbar recruited new nobles to serve the needs of his enlarging empire. In the course of twenty-five years the imperial elite had grown six-fold to 222 amirs. The emperor's fixed goal was to reduce the relative numbers and influence of his Central Asian nobles. To do so, he vigorously recruited Persian entrants into the service. By 1580 Persians numbered forty-seven; Chaghatai and Uzbek Turanis forty-eight.

Beyond this, however, the young leader recruited new men from

⁴ Iqtidar Alam Khan, "The Nobility Under Akbar and the Development of His Religious Policy, 1560-1580," *Journal of the Royal Asiatic Society* (1968), pp. 29-36. Data on the composition and numbers of nobles are taken from this source.

Indian, rather than foreign, racial, and religious backgrounds. Many Indian Muslim warriors had become landed aristocrats as they put down local roots and seized lands from Rajputs and other Hindu groups in North India. Afghans, probably the most numerous body of Indian Muslims, were necessarily excluded. Continuing bitterness and resistance among Afghan grandees in the east meant that Afghan recruitment was not a feasible option for the Timurids.

Other Muslims long resident in North India, but rarely favored with access to political power at the court of the Delhi Sultans, were more pliable. Such, for example, were the Sayyids of Baraha, invariably referred to as brave warriors, whose names begin to appear in imperial annals in the early 1560s. Their ancestor, claiming descent from the Prophet Muhammad, had migrated from Iraq during the thirteenth century and settled in Sirhind near Delhi. From this original settlement numerous descendants proliferated and peopled other villages and lands in the region. Proverbially loyal, the Sayyid leaders could muster several thousand of their bellicose kinsmen for service under Akbar. Other Indian Muslim nobles enlisted to the point that, by 1580, forty-four men (16 percent) of the enlarged nobility were indigenous Muslims.

More significant was Akbar's recruitment of Hindu Rajput leaders into the Mughal nobility. During the fifteenth century Indo-Muslim rulers of regional kingdoms (but not the Sultans of Delhi) had accepted unconverted Hindu warriors into their elite cadres. Even the Surs had benefited from the services of Hemu, a Vaisya administrator and general. Nevertheless, although scarcely unprecedented, this was a major step for the Timurids. In 1561, a minor Rajput chief, head of the Kachhwaha clan of Amber, sought the emperor's intervention in a bid to keep his power against an unfriendly Mughal governor. Bharamall, the Kachhwaha raja, had actively supported Humayun in the conflict with the Surs. When Akbar was marching near Jaipur, the Rajput suppliant offered one of his daughters in marriage to the young monarch. Akbar agreed, the marriage was performed, and the emperor accepted Bharamall, his son, and grandson as amirs in imperial service. The Kachhwaha raja retained his seat at Amber.⁵

Over the next two decades, Akbar demonstrated the reality of Mughal power by repeated campaigns in Rajasthan. Other Rajput

⁵ Kunwar Refaat Ali Khan, *The Kachhwahas Under Akbar and Jahangir* (New Delhi: Kitab Publishing House, 1976).

chiefs negotiated entry into the imperial elite and offered their daughters as marriage partners for the Mughal emperor. By the sixteenth century a diffuse political system based on the obligations of patrilineal kinship and marriage alliances was ripe for political centralization. Several generations of settlement and frontier expansion, driven in large measure by Islamic conquest in the Gangetic valley, resulted in increased productivity and population densities in Rajasthan. Akbar generally recruited Rajput clan heads who either claimed royal blood, or who were the scions of great noble houses. These *thakurs* or masters were the aristocrats of Rajput society in contrast to the more obscure *bhumiya* warriors who possessed only modest power, land and status.

By 1580, Rajputs (and a few other non-Rajput Hindus) numbered forty-three members of the nobility. Each raja was awarded high rank, pay and perquisites. His adult sons, and other close male relatives and kinsmen, obtained lesser *mansabdari* rank as well. In conformity with imperial regulations, Rajput noblemen organized their kinsmen and non-kin retainers into cavalry contingents armed and equipped for active military service. Rajputs were required to serve the emperor personally wherever he might be sent. At court, Rajputs publicly acknowledged the authority and supremacy of the emperor and became conversant with Persian and imperial manners and etiquette. In so doing they were assured that they could retain their beliefs, customs, and honor as Hindu warriors.

In return for imperial rank and privileges the rajas conceded tight Mughal domination over Rajasthan. By placing a *tika* or vermillion mark on the new raja's forehead in court, the emperor legitimized his position. Simultaneously Akbar stipulated rank and precedence and gave the new nobleman valuable ceremonial gifts. The new raja was expected to offer a substantial tribute or *pishkash* as his part of this gift exchange. The emperor conferred the ancestral lands (*watan*) of the raja as his non-transferable holding. These lands were not subject to tribute but their estimated revenues were applied to the pay expected for imperial service. When Bharamall, the Kachhwaha raja, submitted to Akbar, his domain lands consisted of the villages and towns of Amber *pargana* in eastern Rajasthan.⁶ The administration estimated Amber's annual revenues and applied them to the pay and perquisites of the raja according to his rank as a Mughal nobleman. Revenues from

⁶ Satya Prakash Gupta, *The Agrarian System of Eastern Rajasthan (c.1650-c.1750)* (Delhi: Manohar, 1986), p. 5.

several additional parganas within and, in some cases, outside Rajasthan, were assigned to Bharamall as a transferable salary assignment. The number and location of these additional lands fluctuated as the rank and pay of Bharamall and his successors varied. The net effect was to secure the Kachhwaha ancestral lands in Amber from external or internal threats and to make available revenues from other lands to the raja. The intent was to thwart any attempt to enlarge the Amber domains and create a larger state. The emperor made similar arrangements with other Rajputs as they submitted to him.

Akbar clamped tight imperial control over the Rajputs and the new province of Rajasthan. The Rajput lands did not become a set of autonomously ruled tributary kingdoms. Instead, Mughal governance of the province was very similar to other directly administered provinces in the Gangetic plain. A Mughal governor with substantial numbers of troops occupied a newly built imperial fortress at Ajmer, which became the provincial capital. Only imperial currency could circulate; only imperial tolls could be levied on the overland caravan traffic to the Gujarat ports. The standard Mughal revenue system, complete with detailed assessments, land survey and registration, and cash payments for each village became the standard. Those areas not held by Rajput amirs were routinely assigned as transferable revenue producing areas to non-Rajput *mansabdars*. A mixed stratum composed of Rajput *bhumiyas*, Jat and other dominant castes continued to act as intermediaries between the imperial claimants and the producing peasantry.

Submission to the Timurid dynasty did not violate the Rajput *dharma* or inherited code for moral conduct as set out in the bardic literature of the period. The Mughal tie initially encouraged, rather than disrupted, kinship solidarity. Each Rajput nobleman relied heavily upon his kinsmen for military service and advice and counsel. His immediate coterie was formed from his "brotherhood" (*bhai-bamd*) consisting of all males tracing shared patrilineal descent up to six generations.⁷ Each brotherhood formed a kinship unit holding intrinsic power to rule its homelands won by colonization, conquest, and settlement. The larger sphere for recruiting lay in the patrilineal clan, composed of several brotherhoods of varying status and power

⁷ Norman P. Ziegler, "Some Notes on Rajput Loyalties During the Mughal Period" in J. F. Richards, ed., *Kingship and Authority in South Asia*, (Madison Wisconsin, South Asian Studies No. 3, 1978), pp. 231-232.

who together claimed descent from a common male eponymous ancestor. The brotherhood and the clan rose in prestige and power as warriors in Mughal service.

Rajput thakurs who offered their daughters for marriage created a powerful bond between themselves and the Timurid house. The second primary unit of recognition for each Rajput was the brotherhood to which he gave daughters and from which he received wives. Marriage created an alliance with his wife's male relatives that could be called upon at any time for support and assistance.⁸ Although not reciprocal, since no women came from the Mughal side, marriage became an important strand in the ties that bound the Rajputs to the empire. For many thakurs, notably the Rana of Mewar, supplying Rajput noblewomen for the emperor or princes was seen as a disgraceful submission. Those houses who offered brides had made the critical gesture of subordination.

Mughal service was compatible with the ethos of the warrior in service to a great master. Rajputs were enjoined to fight and die in battle in the service of a master. A warrior's service was expressed in acts of complete self-sacrifice and devotion for the earthly master and for god. Salvation for the warrior was the result of such devotion. The Rajput master or thakur acquired his power to conquer and rule by devotion to his god or goddess. The thakur then transmitted the essence of his power and authority to lesser men, also thakurs, who could rule smaller domains within his own. In accepting Akbar's service Rajput thakurs thereby accepted him as a Muslim Rajput who possessed far greater power and sovereignty than even the greatest of Rajput masters. The bardic traditions from this period often "equate [Akbar] with Ram, the pre-eminent Ksatriya cultural hero of the Hindu Rajput."⁹

Both sides benefited by this arrangement. The Timurids won the loyalty of thousands of Rajput warriors, generation after generation. The publicly proclaimed devotion of these prestigious chiefs had its impact on hundreds of lesser Rajput lineages who controlled localities across northern and central India. Akbar preempted the possibility of the rise of another Rajput coalition similar to that which his grandfather had faced at Kanua in 1527. The Rajputs in turn placed themselves within a much wider political arena. Instead of being caught up in local internecine conflicts, they became imperial generals,

⁸ Ibid., p. 224.

⁹ Ibid., p. 235.

statesmen, and high administrators. Instead of being content with the produce of the semi-arid lands of Rajasthan, they diverted streams of wealth from the largess of the empire toward their homelands. Further reinforced by a powerful dynastic appeal, Akbar forged a political bond that would endure for nearly two centuries between Rajput and Mughal.

RANKING

Akbar had created a complex, heterogeneous nobility with divergent experience and cultural expectations. But how could he cope with this diversity? The young emperor resorted to a system of honorific ranks or *mansabs* derived from his Mongol background. These assigned a numerical rank to each officer in imperial service. Each mansabdar or "rank-holder's" status, pay, range of official assignments, and titles were defined by his personal (*zat*) rank. The emperor was the source of all rankings and changes in rankings. As the ranking system evolved, the graded ranks became a supple, powerful instrument to reward or to punish military and civil officers in imperial service.

The decimal ranking order had its origins in the system employed by the Mongols for military commanders. The latter were graded from commanders of ten to those of a hundred, a thousand, and ten thousand troops. The later Timurids continued to employ the terminology although the actual number of troops was often less than the nominal figure in the title. Even the Sur dynasty had employed a similar rank order for its military commanders. From these precedents Akbar created a comprehensive system in which every officer or official was ranked.

In theory, personal rank could be any one of sixty-six even numbered ranks from twenty to five thousand *zat* (or even ten thousand for princes of the blood). In practice only thirty-three ranks were actually in use. Soldiers and bureaucrats alike were mansabdars although higher ranks tended to fall to military commanders rather than financial or judicial specialists. Increases or decreases in rank followed no set rules but were dependent upon royal favor. Especially meritorious service — such as great courage and devotion in battle — resulted often in large increases in rank. Emigré aristocrats from Persia, Turan or elsewhere were given higher ranks as were Rajput chiefs and other powerful local lords who enlisted with Akbar. But these ranks

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did not transfer directly to sons and heirs. A mansabdar could see that his son was enrolled in Mughal service, frequently as a member of his own contingent, but the young aspirant obtained a modest rank in relation to that of his father.

Later in the reign, by the 1590s a second decimal ranking came into use. The *suwar* or "trooper" ranking denoted the number of armed heavy cavalymen each mansabdar was required to recruit, train, command, and pay. In succeeding reigns virtually all mansabdars held *suwar* ranks expressed in even numbers from as little as ten to as high as five thousand. Numerical trooper rank determined the additional funds paid the mansabdar to permit him to maintain his military contingent. In Akbar's time the trooper rank matched the number of cavalry mustered. The latter varied from a small band of ten retainers led by a petty officer to a field army of five thousand horsemen organized by an amir or noble. All cavalry commanded by mansabdars were at the disposal of the emperor. All had to meet strict imperial standards.

This approach fell short of a centrally recruited and paid, bureaucratic, standing army. Instead, organization by military captains and their followers shifted the burden of recruitment, pay, and command to individual mansabdars. By imposing uniform royal standards, Akbar secured the benefits of a large central army without the crushing financial and administrative burden such an entity usually carried with it.

CHITOR AND RANTHAMBOR

Rajput willingness to accept Mughal hegemony was not won without force. In the early 1560s the most prestigious Rajput ruler, the Rana of Mewar, remained defiant. Udai Singh (1540–1572) was descended from the Sisodia ruler Rana Sanga who had died fighting Babur at the battle of Kanua in 1527. As head of the Sisodia clan he possessed the highest ritual status of all the Rajput rajas and chiefs scattered across the landscape of North and Central India. Unless Udai Singh were reduced to submission, the imperial authority of the Timurids would be lessened in Rajput eyes. Akbar, at this early period, was still enthusiastically devoted to the cause of Islam and sought to impress the superiority of his faith over the most prestigious warriors in Brahminical Hinduism.

Udai Singh's son was in uneasy residence in Akbar's court. When asked by Akbar (in jest as Abul Fazl claims) as to whether he would support his father or the emperor in a confrontation, the young Rajput prince fled back to Mewar. Akbar was enraged and determined on war. In September, 1567, the emperor led his armies in a holy war or jihad toward Chitor, the capital of Mewar, a fortified city rising 200 meters above the Rajasthan plain.¹⁰ As the imperial armies approached, Udai Singh's advisers in council concluded that the Sisodia army could not face the Mughals in open battle. Instead, Udai Singh left a 5,000 man garrison in Chitor with supplies to withstand a protracted siege and retreated to a subordinate fortress in the hills. Within a month Akbar laid his siege lines completely around Chitor. His raiding parties devastated the countryside and captured Udaipur, the other leading city.

After initial assaults on the walls failed, taking heavy casualties, the besieging army set up three large batteries to bombard the fort. Simultaneously, imperial sappers commenced digging tunnels for two mines and an approach trench (*sabat*). The artillerymen cast a large siege cannon on site to be used for breaching the walls when the *sabat* reached its objective. At this point the garrison tried to negotiate a surrender on terms; Akbar rejected this overture.

Fifty-eight days into the siege, the sappers had reached the walls and exploded the first of the mines. When the second mine went off it killed about 200 of the assault force caught in the breach. The defenders sealed up the walls. Akbar then pushed ahead with his covered trench to bring his siege cannon within range of the walls. On the night of 22 February, the Mughals made several breaches in the wall and began a general assault. During the melee, Akbar killed Jaimal, the Rajput commander of Chitor, with a well-aimed musket shot, whose death broke the morale of the defenders. Rising pillars of smoke soon signalled the rite of *jauhar* as the Rajputs killed their families and prepared to die in a supreme sacrifice. In a day filled with hand-to-hand struggles virtually all the defenders died. The Mughal troops slaughtered another 20-25,000 ordinary persons, inhabitants of the town and peasants from the surrounding area on the grounds that they had actively helped in the resistance. Only an audacious body of one thousand musketeers, men of Kalpi who had done much damage to the

¹⁰ Abul Fazl, *The Akbar-Nama* (Calcutta: Asiatic Society of Bengal, 3 vols., 1907, 1912, 1939), translated by H. Beveridge II, 464-477.

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Mughals in the siege, managed to escape Akbar's wrath. They bound their wives and children and marched them right through the imperial lines as if they were Mughal troops carrying off prisoners.

Although the imperial armies found little treasure to seize, the fortress was destroyed to the point that it remained deserted thereafter. A victory proclamation (*fath nama*) issued in early March celebrates the successful prosecution of the holy war against the polytheists by the Timurid ruler.¹¹ Udai Singh, however, remained at large, uncaptured by the Mughals until his death four years later. Akbar, for his part, fulfilled an earlier vow by marching on foot to Ajmer in pilgrimage to the shrine of Khwaja Muin-ud-din Chishti. There, during the month of Ramazan, Akbar circumambulated the shrine, gave gifts to the poor and pious, and after ten days returned to Agra.

The next year, in February, 1569, Akbar led his army to an assault on the massive fortress at Ranthambor which, together with Chitor, controlled the major trade corridor to the sea. Rai Surjan, of the Hada lineage, held the fort and its territory as a vassal of Udai Singh. At Ranthambor, the Mughals employed hundreds of bullocks and dozens of elephants to drag fifteen massive siege guns to a hill overlooking the fortress. When, after only a month, these guns started bombarding the fortress and the covered way had reached the walls, the garrison surrendered on terms. Rai Surjan accepted imperial service in return for retention of his ancestral holdings.

The sieges of Chitor and Ranthambor were spectacular public events. The fall of these great forts demonstrated the reality of Mughal power for every warrior in North India. Outright defiance to the Mughal emperor was not possible; submission or death was the only choice.

IMPERIAL STRONGHOLDS

At the same time that he was demonstrating the inability of any fortress, however strong, to defy his assaults, Akbar was busily engaged in constructing his own strategic network of strongholds. His first concern was to fortify his capital at Agra, "which by position is the centre of Hindustan." In 1565 after "lofty minded mathematicians and able architects laid the foundations" the massive walls and four gates of the fort began to rise on the banks of the Yamuna river:¹²

¹¹ K. A. Nizami, *Akbar and Religion* (Delhi, 1989), pp. 383-399.

¹² *Ibid.*, p. 372.

Every day 3 to 4,000 active builders and strong-armed labourers carried on the work. From the foundations to the battlements, the fortress was composed of hewn stones, each of which was polished like a world-revealing mirror, and was ruddy as the cheek of fortune. And they were so joined together that the end of a hair could not find a place between them. This sublime fortress . . . was completed with its battlements, breastwork, and its loop-holes . . . in the space of eight years under the faithful superintendence of Musim Khan Mir Barr u Bahr.

The massive red fortress contained over five hundred buildings when completed. Still standing today it "was to be stable like the foundation of the domination of the sublime family and permanent like the pillars of its fortunes."¹³

Over the next two decades, Akbar, as part of his grand strategy, erected two other huge palace fortresses. Allahabad (formerly the Hindu city of Prayag), guarded the conjunction of the Ganges and Yamuna rivers in the eastern Gangetic plain. Lahore, the capital of the Punjab, was the first line of defense against an assault over the northwest passes from Afghanistan or Central Asia – the classic invasion route. These three large fortress and palace complexes, defended by heavy cannon, were virtually impregnable to direct assault. The emperor further anchored this defensive line by building a strongly defended castle (begun 1570) at Ajmer, the gateway to the Rajasthan corridor. He strengthened the strategically placed frontier strongholds in the northwest at Attock and Rohtas on the Indus. In the east the bastion of Rohtas in Bihar stood guard.

The Lahore, Agra, Allahabad, Ajmer quadrilateral formed a protective framework for Mughal imperial power. The great walls of these bastions secured growing hoards of imperial treasure and massive arsenals, and provided ultimate safety for the person of the emperor and his court and household. Fortress commanders, who received their appointments directly from the emperor, were responsible directly to the imperial court. To ensure their autonomy the custom grew up of assigning revenues from those villages and lands surrounding each fortress to meet the needs of the garrison. The Mughals occupied and garrisoned many other famous strongholds as they expanded, including Gwalior, and the great forts of Rajasthan – Chitor, Ranthambor and Mirtha – as well as Asirgarh (near Burhanpur) and the massive hill forts of the Deccan provinces. Nevertheless, imperial security rested on the great strongholds in Hindustan – the very center of the empire.

¹³ Ibid., p. 372.